regions in seven states, this first-of-its-kind initiative shifts the focus to community-driven, demand-side management of groundwater.

Spanning 6.7 lakh hectares, the program promotes efficient irrigation—drip, sprinkler, mulching, and crop diversification—to curb water wastage. Over 70,000 wells are being monitored at the grassroots level, with real-time data shared with local communities. More than 93,000 water conservation and recharge structures have been mapped, and 1,333 Gram Panchayats have already recorded improved groundwater levels.

India's **National Aquifer Mapping Programme (NAQUIM)** complements these efforts by offering the world's largest groundwater mapping initiative. Covering 25 lakh sq. km, it provides the scientific foundation for sustainable groundwater management.

The water conservation drive showcases **seamless inter-ministerial coordination and a whole-of-government approach** to building a Viksit Bharat. Under the Rural Development Ministry's MGNREGA programme, the Natural Resource Management (NRM) and Amrit Sarovar initiatives have seen massive execution, with Rs 1.17 lakh crore spent for JSA:CTR water-related structures and over Rs 46,000 crore for Amrit Sarovars. Other ministries— including Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Housing & Urban Affairs, Environment & Climate Change, Education, Women & Child Development, Agriculture and department of land resources—have bolstered the Jal Shakti Ministry's mission with their own initiatives.

From securing drinking water to sustaining agriculture, these efforts form the lifeblood of India's water renaissance. Yet, no revolution thrives without its quiet sentinels. Scattered across the nation, in sun-scorched fields and bustling towns, farmers, engineers, and social workers have become custodians of a vanishing resource, turning despair into renewal. The National Water Awards honor these guardians—those who have battled scarcity not with resignation, but with resolve, proving that a **Jal Samridh Bharat** is not a distant dream but a living movement, a solemn promise, a future etched by hands that refuse to yield to drought and depletion. These awardees and several others are India's water warriors—silent yet steadfast. From remote villages to bustling cities, from forgotten wells to rejuvenated rivers, their stories are testaments of resilience and ingenuity. These 20 water warriors are rewriting India's water story, one drop at a time. ▪



HS Lalawmpuii, 51
Sairep, Lunglei, Mizoram

What makes her a water warrior: In the remote village of Sairep, Mizoram, HS Lalawmpuii turned a water crisis into a conservation triumph. As Village Council President, she led afforestation drives, rainwater harvesting, and infrastructure development, doubling **storage capacity to 6.9 lakh litres**. Mobilizing government funds and community efforts, she instilled a culture of conservation, with women playing a key role through ***shramdaan***. Her leadership transformed Sairep into a model of sustainability, proving that true change begins at the grassroots. By blending advocacy with action, she didn't just secure water—she empowered her village to safeguard its future.



Basanti Devi, 64
Pithoragarh, Uttarakhand

What makes her a water warrior: Basanti Devi led a grassroots revolution to revive Uttarakhand's Kosi River, once threatened by deforestation and erosion. Mobilizing local women, she formed forest protection groups to replant trees, restoring groundwater recharge and strengthening the river's flow. Her approach was simple yet transformative—**revive the forests, and the river will return**. Without waiting for government intervention, she empowered villagers to reclaim their water resources, ensuring a sustainable future. Through patience and community action, Basanti Devi proved that true conservation is driven by people, not policies—her legacy is a river reborn and a movement that endures.

Ujiaro Bai, 39
Dindori, Madhya Pradesh



What makes her a water warrior: Ujiaro Bai has dedicated her life to conserving water and forests, mobilizing the Baiga community under the motto "**Jal, Jangal, Zameen.**" Through the Durga Self-Help Group, she fought reckless deforestation, restoring groundwater recharge and ensuring water security. Her efforts empowered women to join the movement, fostering a culture of sustainability. Taking her mission global, she addressed conservation challenges in South Africa and Finland, showcasing India's environmental ethos. By uniting communities against water scarcity, Ujiaro Bai has turned conservation into a way of life, proving that grassroots leadership is key to a water-secure future.